Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on an Analysis of Lovelace's "To Lucasta" and Fehler's Parody

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of these poems include

alliteration
apostrophe
inversion
euphemism
metonymy
sight/eye rhyme

Fehler's parody suggests that the field on which honor is achieved is no longer the battle field but the sports field and, additionally, that fidelity might well be relative.

The juxtaposing of honor, an abstraction, with money, a representation of materialism, suggests moral decline—despite the paradoxical underlying reality that people die in wars in which men act honorably and people don't die (as a matter of course) on fields of dreams or in sports stadiums, where money seems to be the driving force behind the offering of oneself up for the glory of winning.

The contestant might recognize that the leaving of one "mistress" for another is, in any estimation, a question of fidelity. The same might be argued in the case of a team member and his loyalty to the fans under whose "kind cheers" that athlete has achieved his fame.

The commentary might rely on an item-by-item analysis in which the honor-money dichotomy and the mistress-sports fans dichotomy are recognized as the pivotal points of comparison.

Another approach has the two dichotomies acting as support for a thesis that notes that each poet recognizes the importance (fidelity) that men give achievement and glory—in short, significance—in the public arena (on either of the two fields) in comparison to the comparably slight importance (fidelity) associated with the private sphere: one's lover or one's hometown fans.

The perspicacious and culturally alert contestant might find the unfortunately interesting Pat Tillman story suggestively apropos.